

THE CHARISMATIC MOVEMENT — THE AMBIGUOUS CHALLENGE

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CONFLICTING VIEWS ON CHARISMATICS AND POLITICS

"Pseudo-piety (which sees the gospel as having nothing to do with socio-political issues and being acontextual, 'spiritual' and a private matter) abounds within the white South African community. It is certainly encouraged by those in power, *stimulated by tendencies within such movements as the charismatic renewal*, and reinforced by the processes of secularisation."¹

This is the opinion of Prof. John de Gruchy of the University of Cape Town in a recent article on current theological debate in South Africa. In so far as he associates the charismatic renewal movement with a lack of societal involvement he is probably reflecting the generally accepted view amongst most theologians. After analysing the statements of a wide variety of churches on the charismatic renewal Kilian McDonnell of Collegeville, Minnesota, states: "When the documents spoke on the social implications of the gospel, they almost unanimously faulted the charismatic renewal."² In stark contrast to this majority opinion Rifkin and Howard, described as "nonevangelical, political activist outsiders" from the staff of the Peoples' Business Commission in Washington DC, declare: "The charismatics are providing the kind of liberating energy that is essential for any full-scale assault on the authority of the existing economic (and political) order."³ They even go further: "In fact, the Charismatic movement is probably the single most political movement in America today — not in the everyday sense of advancing particular issues and concerns — but in a much deeper, more profound sense. Though largely unconscious of its own incredible politicization (read: politicisation — HIL), the Charismatic movement is a barometer of deep changes in the American psyche that are threatening to topple the existing economic order . . ."⁴

I do not believe that the distance between Washington and Cape Town has much to do with the varying emphases of de Gruchy and Rifkin. It will

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1. John W. de Gruchy, Theologies in conflict: the South African debate, in *Resistance and Hope. South African essays in honour of Beyers Naudé*, edited by Charles Villa-Vicencio and John W. de Gruchy. Cape Town and Johannesburg: David Philip, 1985, p. 96 (for the sake of brevity I have rearranged this sentence whilst, I believe, not changing any aspect of de Gruchy's intention. The emphasis is also mine — HIL).

2. Kilian McDonnell (editor), *Presence Power Praise Documents on the Charismatic Renewal*. Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1980, Vol 1, p. iii.

3. Jeremy Rifkin with Ted Howard, *The Emerging Order. God in the Age of Scarcity*. New York: Putman, 1979, p.169.

4. *Ibid*, p. 181.

be the contention of this paper that they are both right, or rather, that with the necessary delineation it will become clear that there are legitimate elements in both of these conflicting evaluations of the political role of the charismatic movement.

REFLECTING ON OUR THEME or WHAT IN THE WORLD IS THE WORLD?

Most people familiar with the renewal movement would probably not question (at least on a primary level) that charismatics have living churches. They may, however, wonder if these living (lively?) charismatic churches are really challenging the *world*?

It seems to me to be almost indisputable that the charismatic movement has presented a fundamental challenge to the *church*. Its impact on Christianity has been impressive. It may yet prove to be the most powerful religious awakening of the century. During the 'sixties and 'seventies this lay revivalist movement without structured organisation and unified leadership spread rapidly across the globe and made its influence felt in all five continents and in practically every denomination of Protestant (since 1958), Roman Catholic (since 1967) and Eastern Orthodox (since 1971) heritage. In this process the lives of some sixty million people were touched and opened up to new levels of religious experience and faith. In this way traditional Christendom (its theology, practice and liturgy) was questioned.

Perhaps the most effective theological challenge of the charismatics was that presented to the dispensationalist theories of biblical fundamentalism. This heritage of the Scofield Reference Bible and Dallas Theological Seminary (delightfully dubbed "streepteologie" in Afrikaans) taught that the *charismata* of 1 Corinthians 12, the extraordinary or more supernatural gifts of the Holy Spirit such as tongues, healings and prophecy were limited to the bygone apostolic dispensation — God having drawn a line, putting an end to such miracles, upon the death of the last apostle (calculated to be $\pm$ AD 150 by B.B. Warfield) or at the third or fourth century closing of the canon of New Testament writings (arguing ingeniously from the verse in 1 Corinthians 13 "when that which is perfect [Scripture!] is come, then that which is in part [charisms] shall be done away"). Backed up by more recent biblical scholarship in especially the Roman Catholic and Reformed traditions, charismatics have dismissed dispensationalism and challenged Christianity to take seriously the continuing existence of charismatic gifts. Even the theologically conservative Nederduitse Gereformeerde Church of South Africa acknowledged that God in his sovereignty could not be limited in this way and accepted a stance in 1978 which is theoretically open to the full range of charisms.⁵

5. Compare the statement of the General Synod of 1978: *Riglyne ten opsigte van die charismatiese beweging en die charismatiese gewoes. Algemene Kommissie Leer en Aktuele Sake NGK*. Pretoria: N.G. Kerkboekhandel, 1979.

If it be established that the charismatic renewal movement (henceforth CRM) has challenged theology and the church, what then of the *world*? This is the crucial question. The world and the church should be differentiated in this context even though it may be true that there is much of the world in the church as well as of the church in the world. Naturally the world is here not to be understood geographically. To be able to evaluate the CRM's challenge to the world one needs to give some content to what is being understood by the rather amorphous term: the world.

When used in contradistinction to the church the world is generally taken to refer to sinful, unrepentant humanity and its culture. The devil is described by John as "the prince of this world" (Jn. 12:31, 14:30 and 16:11). Richard Niebuhr in his classic *Christ and Culture* (1951) has outlined five enduring paradigms for the relationship between the Christian faith and secularised culture: accommodation (the Christ of culture), separation (Christ against culture), synthesis (Christ above culture), dualism (Christ and culture in paradox) and conversion (Christ the Transformer of culture). Needless to say most ethicists seem to opt for the last paradigm which Niebuhr saw personified in the approach towards the world taken by Augustine, Calvin and, especially, the British Christian socialist, F.D. Maurice. It has become a cornerstone of modern social ethics that the challenge of the world is to be countered not only on the personal and individual levels. The Christian church has a prophetic responsibility to protest against the structural and systemic dimensions of evil in society and to work for their transformation and conversion. The present political regime in South Africa seems oblivious to this perspective, judging from its repeated calls that the clergy desist from political comment and affirm "a gospel which addresses 'only truly spiritual purposes', leaving politics to the secular forces of 'national interest' " — as pointed out by Charles Villa-Vicencio with respect to the Eloff Commission.⁶

This is the *first criterion* which will be used to evaluate the societal relevance of the CRM — the extent to which it espouses a transformationist ethic which reaches right down to the structural dimensions of secularised society.

Related to this is the less visible, more philosophical challenge of the world — if you will, the struggle against "the powers and principalities" (Eph. 5:12) which operate on the level of attitudes and forces of which we are often not even fully aware. Here I am referring not to public societal structuring but to ideas such as materialism, rationalism, individualism, positivism, etc. These are the false gods of the Western world. They are destroying our humanity, our ecosystem and our future. They will provide the *second criterion* for evaluating the societal relevance of the CRM, i.e. its challenge to the world.

6. Charles Villa-Vicencio, Theology in the service of the state: the Steyn and Eloff Commissions, in *Resistance and Hope*, p. 113. See footnote 1 for further details.

Having thus given some content to what the world is (without attempting to try and “define” it) the stage is now clear to begin to evaluate the societal role of the CRM, using these two related criteria. However, some remarks need first to be made about the diversity that is to be found in the CRM.

PRIMARY DISTINCTIONS or WHAT IN THE WORLD IS THE CRM?

The CRM is no monolith. The variety of its theological and societal views is practically as broad as that of Christianity at large. For this very reason I chose not to analyse one particular case study such as New Jerusalem Community, Cincinnati, Ohio or the Episcopal Church of the Redeemer, Houston, Texas or even the Christian Community Centre (previously Hatfield Baptist), Pretoria. However fascinating such a detailed study may be, no one case could even come close to presenting something of the panorama of positions to be found in the CRM.

I shall not attempt to describe the short history of the CRM or present an update on its present state. Rather I wish to make some primary distinctions amongst charismatic using first *structure* and then *theology* as classification principles.⁷

Structurally considered there are at least *four* basic types of charismatics. (By *charismatics* I mean those people who became involved experientially in the CRM which started roughly in the 1960s — *not* to be confused with classical Pentecostalism and its denominations such as the Assemblies of God, the Apostolic Faith Mission or the various Church of God denominations which all started at the beginning of the century.)

(i) *Denominational charismatics*. This is by far the largest grouping. These are the charismatic Christians who recognised in the CRM something essentially compatible with their particular confessional tradition, be it Roman Catholic, Greek Orthodox, Jewish Messianic, Anglican, Lutheran, Presbyterian and Reformed, Methodist or Baptist. They have remained in their respective churches but are linked together as charismatics through denominational charismatic structures which organise regional conferences and prayer groups, and publish periodicals, e.g. Presbyterian and Reformed Renewal Ministries International, the New Covenant Magazine (Catholic), the annual Lutheran Conferences on the Holy Spirit in Minneapolis, etc.

(ii) Charismatics in *para-church organisations* which usually have an inter-denominational structure such as Youth with a Mission, Christian Broadcasting Network, etc.

(iii) *Independent “non-denominational” charismatics*. These charismatic Christians have left their respective churches (or chosen not to join existing

7. For further information about the theological classifications see my (as yet) unpublished Unisa doctoral thesis *Treasures Old and New* (1986). For the sake of brevity several perspectives which have been developed separately in that study are here grouped together under category (c) Integrative.

churches) to form either entirely local independent Christian centres or to join the new burgeoning church-planting groups such as Rhema Bible Church, Vineyard Christian Fellowship, Maranatha Ministries or the Restorationist “House Church” fellowships.

(iv) The *intentional communities* form a quite different structural category. They express their shared covenantal life in varying forms of communal living. Although representing a relatively small number of people these communities (banded together in international networks such as the Sword of the Spirit, The People of Praise, the Shalom Covenant) often provide leadership and resources for the wider CRM. They can be denominational or independent but are usually ecumenical.

Using *theology* as classification principle a different set of categories emerge:

(a) *Neo-Pentecostal*. Here the basic tenets of classical Pentecostal theology have been retained with minor modifications. Such views include espousing the “theology of subsequence” or two-stage pattern for Christian life and considering glossolalia as a sign of the necessary initial, physical evidence of Spirit-baptism. Examples of this perspective can be found in the writings of charismatic leaders such as Dennis Bennett (Episcopal), Steve Clark (Catholic), Rodman Williams (Presbyterian) and Howard Ervin (Baptist).

(b) *Sacramental*. Here charismatic teaching has been adapted to fit the sacramental framework of the Catholic, Orthodox, Anglican and Lutheran traditions. The central charismatic doctrine of Spirit-baptism is viewed as an experiential “release” of the Spirit previously bestowed in the sacraments of Christian initiation, namely infant baptism and confirmation. Leading proponents are Cardinal Suenens, Edward O’Connor, Simon Tugwell and Donald Gelpi from the Roman Catholic Church, the Lutheran, Ted Jungkuntz, and the Episcopalian, James Jones.

(c) *Integrative*. An integrative, evangelical (non-sacramental) approach is taken by others. Here the charismatic experience is fully integrated into regular Christianity — it is seen as a fresh coming of the Spirit, a growth experience, the fullness of the Spirit or a spiritual breakthrough without any event-centredness or elitist ultimacy being associated with this charismatic dimension of life. In effect this approach boils down to a recognition of the experiential nature of the Christian faith and an openness to the full range of charisms which the Spirit distributes to the congregation. Examples are Tom Smail and Barbara Pursey (Reformed), Michael Cassidy (Anglican), Tormod Engelsen and Arnold Bittlinger (Lutheran), Bob Tuttle (Methodist), Siegfried Grossmann (Baptist) and Heribert Mühlen and Francis Sullivan (Catholic).

These two sets of classification should be kept in mind as we now set about answering the fundamental question: How does the CRM challenge the world?

EVALUATION OF THE CRM's CHALLENGE ON A STRUCTURAL LEVEL — FOUR POSITIONS

Working within a framework which views a transformational challenge to the world as the ultimate goal one can distinguish four different groups or approaches currently represented within the CRM.

(1) The first position represents *no effectual challenge* at all. These charismatics seem to be totally apolitical although this usually boils down to a subtle support for the status quo. It has already been pointed out above that the failure to see and respond to the societal implications of the gospel is a common and major criticism of the CRM. This view usually separates religion and public life into watertight compartments. The slogans are: "Don't mix religion and politics" and "Change people's hearts and you will change their society as well." Representatives of this position claim that the world *is* being effectively challenged by their ministries — through evangelism and the saving of "souls". They also state that this stance in the CRM is largely a reaction to what is perceived as an overemphasis on social involvement in the so-called "social gospel".⁸ This is the approach of some old-style evangelists like Billy Graham in his earlier years and is by no means limited to charismatics! Helping people to become reconciled with God and to discover new life in Jesus is truly significant but if it does not lead to acknowledging the Lordship of Christ over all of life and obedience and commitment to his kingly rule it hardly represents much of a challenge to the secular world.

It is impossible to accurately gauge how many charismatics fall into this category. The situation also differs vastly from country to country and very little research has been done specifically about charismatics and their involvement in society. One notable exception to this needs to be mentioned. Joseph Fichter has discussed the views of Roman Catholics in the renewal in his book *The Catholic Cult of the Paraclete*. He found three heterodox teachings amongst them (heterodox from the viewpoint of Roman Catholicism), namely that the Second Coming of Christ is imminent, that "accepting Jesus as my personal Savior means I am already saved" and that "the Spirit speaks to the heart — not the mind."⁹ I don't expect these views to lead to any heresy trials in Protestantism!

Fichter's research substantiates the opinion that Catholic charismatics have a low record of participation in social action programmes but he says this is probably typical of American Catholic laity (non-charismatic as well).¹⁰ He provides an interesting explanation for the lack of societal action in prayer groups: "the need for internal harmony, for peaceful Catholic unity, is considered to be fundamental to the local prayer community.

8. McDonnell, *op. cit.*, Vol.1, p.iii.

9. Joseph H Fichter, *The Catholic Cult of the Paraclete*. New York: Sheed and Ward, 1975, p.44.

10. *Ibid*, p.91.

The members are not likely to fight about theological and scriptural interpretations, but *they are convinced that concrete proposals for organized social action would tear them apart*. The findings of our survey demonstrate that *despite their spiritual unity, the members have not abandoned their diverse political and social convictions*. In their religious convictions they are basically of one-mind-in-the-Spirit, but in social matters they still range along the whole continuum from very liberal to very conservative.”¹¹ As a result many charismatics get involved in the level of *personal care for the needs of others* — the corporate works of mercy (discussed below in position 3) and those who desire to involve themselves in socio-political action programmes *participate in “outside” groups* co-operating with non-charismatics to alleviate social injustice. (This will be dealt with in position 4.)

It is interesting to note in passing that *classical Pentecostals* (whose views have been more thoroughly researched) vary from “politically disinterested” in Chile and “very weak socio-political engagement” amongst Indian Pentecostals in South Africa to “increased engagement in society by the Central American Pentecostals” and the situation in Sweden where a new political party, the Christian Democratic Party, was formed in 1964 — the first in the world with Pentecostals as the core group, the elderly Pentecostal churchman, Lewi Pethrus, becoming vice-chairman of the party. He had argued since 1944: “It was biblical . . . not to dissociate from the development of society and the decision-making process, but it was a Christian duty to engage oneself actively in it. It was real Christianity not only to pray and praise God but also to work in the direction of the prayer.”¹² This high degree of societal involvement (the forming of a political party) was preceded and facilitated by a Pentecostal newspaper, *Dagen*, which had started way back in 1945, almost twenty years before the founding of the Christian Democratic Party.

The same variety of approaches found amongst Pentecostals could also in time be expected to develop within the CRM. One may with safety make the generalisation that the independent and neo-Pentecostal charismatics tend more towards being societally “uninvolved” than the denominational charismatics. This also seems to be supported by the research done by Morran and Schlemmer in the greater Durban area. Their survey entitled *Faith for the fearful*¹³ found that 90% of the members questioned from the independent “non-denominational” churches which have emerged in the last ten years profess to a lack of interest in politics and 100% agreed with

11. *Ibid.*, p.93.

12. The quotations in this digression on Pentecostals are all from Carl-Erik Sahlberg's article The Pentecostal — a homo religious or a homo politicus? in *The Pentecostal movement — five case studies*. Nairobi: Evangel Publishing House, 1985, pp.20-37. They are to be found respectively on pages 22, 23, 32 and 28. Another interesting analysis of the differing societal roles played by Pentecostals can be found in Günter Remmert, Spiritual movements and political praxis, in *Spirituality. Religious Revival*, edited by C. Duquoc and C. Floristan (Concilium 9.9) pp.85-97.

13. E.S. Morran and L. Schlemmer, *Faith for the Fearful? An investigation into new churches in the greater Durban area*. Durban: Univ of Natal Centre for Applied Social Sciences, 1984.

the statement that "the only way this country and the world will come right is through prayer and the spreading of the gospel."¹⁴

It is necessary to keep in mind that the stereotyped perception of the religious pressure group always tending towards the left of the political spectrum is fast becoming obsolete. America is discovering that this traditional perception and heritage of the turbulent 'sixties is being increasingly countered by right-wing Christian (including charismatic) groups. The time may soon come that the "liberal" social activist will no longer decry the disinterestedness of many evangelical and charismatic Christians but fervently wish that they would once more recede into an apolitical stance!

(2) The next position found in the CRM is that of *moral* protest. This seems inevitably to be the following step on the scale of involvement in societal issues. Here the focus is still largely negative. A vast number of charismatics are joining forces to object to public moral issues, often related to sexual sins. Examples are protests against pornography, the liberalising of abortion and divorce laws, gambling, prostitution, homo-sexuality, drug and alcohol addiction. It should be acknowledged that these activities do represent a challenge to the world although they are often of a more local or regional nature. Two illustrations will have to suffice. Members of an independent restoration type community (Silver Spring Covenant Community in Washington, DC) have a ministry picketing abortion clinic lines often succeeding in convincing young mothers-to-be, usually from the poorer classes, to rather have the child adopted and then providing them with a place of refuge, accommodation and caring support for the rest of the pregnancy within their community households. Another example of this level of moral protest is the disseminating of thousands of copies of *Healing for the Homosexual*¹⁵ by the Presbyterian Charismatic Communion and various counselling facilities that are provided for this type of outreach.

(3) The next level of societal involvement found amongst charismatics is that of welfare or *mercy ministries*. Aid is provided for the underprivileged, the handicapped, aged, mentally ill, poor, illiterate, refugees, victims of famine, earthquakes, etc. This work is paralleled by similar efforts in the large mainline denominations and even the welfare of the state. It is often of a local nature. Large inner-city charismatic parishes such as the Church of the Redeemer in Houston, Texas, are actively involved in a variety of outreaches in their neighbourhoods.¹⁶ Another example is the sterling work done by charismatic Catholics from El Paso, Texas in ministering to the impoverished and destitute in nearby Juarez, Mexico.¹⁷

It is significant that to my knowledge practically every charismatic inten-

14. *Ibid.*, pp.76, 77.

15. Brick Bradford et al., *Healing for the Homosexual*, Oklahoma City: Presbyterian Charismatic Communion, 1978.

16. Cf. Michael Harper, *A new way of living. How the Church of the Redeemer, Houston, found a new life-style*. Plainfield, NJ: Logos International, 1973, and Graham Pulkingham, *Gathered for Power*. London: Hodder and Stoughton, 1972.

17. Cf. René Laurentin, *Miracles in El Paso*. Ann Arbor: Servant, 1982.

tional community is deeply involved in this kind of ministry to the poor. Whereas charismatic congregations can sometimes avoid their responsibilities in this regard, communities, by the very nature of their communal life, seem to be more aware of the needs of the poor and underprivileged. A particular facet of the charismatic approach to this level of societal involvement seems to be the time given to prayer and the careful seeking of God's guidance in the selection of a particular project at a specific time, rather than indiscriminately trying to answer any need of which one becomes aware. Larry Christenson sees this fact as being a distinct advantage over against the "social gospellers" in his book *A Charismatic Approach to Social Action*.¹⁸ An increasing percentage of charismatics are becoming involved in some or other kind of mercy ministry.

(4) The last category of CRM societal involvement is that of *structural reform and systemic transformation*. A small but dedicated number of charismatics, especially those involved in the Community of Communities in the United States, are working along these lines. Activist lobbying on the left is a well-known phenomenon. There are charismatics seeking to convince American Christendom that a nuclear freeze is called for and that the Reagan administration's policy in Central America is fundamentally unjust. Individual charismatics are involved in the "sanctuary" initiative to help "illegal" refugees and immigrants. The social activist community in Washington DC, Sojourners, led by Jim Wallis, has a sizeable charismatic component. The renowned Franciscan charismatic preacher, Richard Rohr of Cincinnati, travels widely, speaking on spirituality as well as topics such as the Christian response to global issues, preferential options for the poor, and liberation theology. Dr Allen Howe of Reba Place Fellowship in Evanston, Illinois, is deeply involved in the Peace Movement, taking part in demonstrations and appearing in television debates. At "Pentecost 1983" a hundred or so charismatics even got themselves arrested in the Capitol building in Washington for staging an "illegal" prayer demonstration against the nuclear arms race. This has become known as "Peace Pentecost."

Issues of a structural nature that have been analysed at charismatic conferences include racial discrimination, capital punishment, "Witness for Peace in Nicaragua", feminism, the global ecological emergency, identification with the poor, and nuclear war.¹⁹ Kevin Ranaghan has addressed himself to the following topics: "The Evangelisation of Culture", "Jesus Christ: Hope for the Transformation of Society", and *Renew the face of the Earth — Christians in the modern world*.²⁰

Charismatics on the right are also slowly becoming more involved in sys-

18. This was the original title. It is now published under the title *Social Action Jesus Style*. Minneapolis: Bethany, 1976.

19. These were all dealt with in workshops at the Summer Festival of the Community of Communities at Hope College, Holland, Michigan, in July 1984. Most (but not all) people involved with this conference were charismatic.

20. The first two titles are taped addresses whilst the last one is a brochure — South Bend: Charismatic Renewal Services, 1982.

temic issues — usually in co-operation with non-charismatic evangelicals. The non-denominational independent group, Maranatha Ministries, openly advocates a variety of right-wing causes at its “high-powered” charismatic conferences, as does Pat Robertson of the Christian Broadcasting Network. The so-called “Moral Majority” of Jerry Falwell espouses a distinctly “involved” and political profile. Christians are urged to vote in congressional elections according to the score cards drawn up from positions taken by the candidates on issues such as abortion, the Equal Rights Amendment, voluntary prayer in schools, and even the Panama Canal Treaty, the state of Israel and Taiwan! Falwell is *not* a charismatic and the many Pentecostals and charismatics (even in South Africa) who endorse his approach would be surprised to learn that according to reports glossolalia is strictly forbidden at Liberty Baptist College.

Both on the right and the left there is a great deal of overlap and co-operation between charismatics and non-charismatics when it comes to structural issues ranging from protesting the pervasive threats of a nuclear holocaust and hunger to advocating unbridled capitalistic expansionism and the removal of “statist” curbs on free enterprise. Some small differences do exist showing that charismatic activists are not undiscerning in their positions. As far as I could determine, charismatics all remain consistently “pro-family” and “pro-life”. Although in many large Protestant denominations the following causes are openly advocated, I am unaware of a pro-abortion or pro-“gay” rights lobby in the CRM.

We now need to turn briefly to the charismatic scene in *South Africa*. Here the whole spectrum of options is not represented. Most South African charismatics seem to be hovering somewhere between Positions 2 and 3.

It is, however — given the mounting political pressures in South African society as a whole — merely a matter of time before this will change. Already we are finding in the small charismatic community movement an incisive, if low-key, protest against racial discrimination. In the Sword of the Spirit Community in Johannesburg the communal life not only embraces various denominations; it also reaches across the colour bar.

Due to historical and societal reasons the nature of the CRM in South Africa is somewhat different from the global picture. One marked difference is that it has had little impact on the Reformed and Lutheran churches (denominations which also have a deep entanglement with the policy of apartheid in common). Roman Catholics (who do *not* share a heritage of racial separation) also have comparatively few charismatics in their ranks when compared with North or South America — probably due to limited support from the hierarchy. The major impact of the renewal has been amongst Anglicans, some Presbyterians, and especially Independents and non-denominational Baptists.

On the level of conjecture I believe it could quite easily happen that

charismatic Anglicans, as they become more distinctly visible as an identifiable group, having become organised through a denominational charismatic committee (like the USA Episcopalians and the South African Catholics), could reach the level of systemic societal involvement on the left, whilst independent charismatics such as the newly formed International Fellowship of Christian Churches (including the Rhema Bible Church and the previous Hatfield Baptist Church) could possibly become more socially involved in support of political structures on the right. (In order to clarify the emotive words *left* and *right* let me state the opinion that on a party-political level I consider the Progressive Federal Party to be centrist and consequently left and right can here be taken to refer to left and right of that particular stance in the South African political arena.)

Since the racial issue is the dominant one in political debate in South Africa and the pressure for change seems to be increasing daily, it is to be expected that the Christian responses to this societal problem will in the future become more vociferous on a structural level. One does not need prophetic insight to see that the dividing line between the Christian responses is not likely to be charismatic versus non-charismatic but rather between the vested interests of the left and the right. We have recently noted the emergence of two kinds of different Christian initiatives in response to the present state of emergency: on the one hand the broadly based National Initiative for Reconciliation and on the other Christians for Peace, United Christian Action, and *Signposts*. Prominent charismatic leaders are to be found in *both* groups.

In conclusion it thus appears that charismatics can be found in varying degrees on all four levels of societal involvement, probably with a numerical preponderance in the second and third positions. Although they may have their own style of relating to societal issues their positions do not seem to be determined by their being charismatic or not, but rather by factors of an intrinsically political nature. Charismatics, together with other Christians, are found to be presenting their challenges to the world on the levels of evangelism, moral protest, mercy ministries and structural transformation. As the CRM continues to mature in the third decade of its existence it is likely that more charismatics will become involved on the level of structural transformation — whether this involvement will be conservative or progressive will not *per se* depend on charismatic teaching.

Returning to de Gruchy's quotation in my opening paragraph I would like to conclude that pseudopiety which denies the socio-political implications of the gospel is indeed stimulated by tendencies within the CRM. This assertion is fundamentally correct, but incomplete. There are also other tendencies within the CRM which are increasingly tugging it in the direction of deeper societal involvement. Using the criterion of structural involvement to evaluate the societal relevance of the CRM it is necessary to state that its challenge to the world in this regard is woefully inadequate.

The *majority* of charismatics have not become involved in society on the level of systemic issues regardless of what their political views may be.

The most hopeful sign that this may change in future is the number of new publications (dealing with structural issues) coming from within the CRM.²¹

EVALUATING THE CRM'S CHALLENGE ON THE LEVEL OF WORLD-VIEW

This brings us to the other, more abstract, level of determining the CRM's challenge to the World. This second criterion functions on the level of "the battle for the mind", of attitudes and world-views. Dominant concepts in Western culture such as materialism, rationalism, individualism, etc., were identified above and can be multiplied. Brief attention will here be given to only two concepts: individualism and materialism.

By its very existence the CRM presents a formidable challenge to the classic Western outlook of rugged *individualism*. Over against the impersonal and functional human relationships of technological society the charismatic emphasises personal relationships and the interdependence of people. Rather than the "lone star" leader approach the charismatic movement is largely a lay (unordained) movement with particular focus on *body ministry* and team leadership. This tends to foster mutual interdependence and solidarity amongst those involved. A strong sense of fellowship and belonging is an important factor which attracts many people to the CRM, especially the young, singles, those suffering from deep hurts and those not blessed with a heritage of sound family relationships. In modern society that adds up to a large slice of the population. Charismatic prayer groups are very often centres of love, warmth and mutual caring support. In this atmosphere people are enabled to share their problems and receive healing. The shackles of individualism are broken and meaningful relationships can be built. Through the "rediscovery" of the *charismata* and their free-flowing manifestation in charismatic services interdependence and the communal spirit are fostered. The basic intention of 1 Corinthians 12 is that God gives gifts to all for the sake of the common good and mutual up-building. Not all are prophets or workers of miracles or tongue-speakers,

21. Apart from Ranaghan and Rohr, who have already been referred to, the following can be mentioned: Sheila Macmanus Fahey, *Charismatic Social Action*. New York: Paulist, 1977; Cardinal Suenens and Dom Helder Camara, *Charismatic Renewal and Social Action: A Dialogue*. Malines Document 3. Ann Arbor: Servant, 1979; Cardinal Suenens, Charismatic Christians and "Social" Christians, in *Essays on Renewal*, Ann Arbor: Servant, 1977, pp.71-76; Paul Felton, Towards a Charismatic Social Theology, in *Theological Renewal* 8, Feb./Mar. 1978, pp.22-29; Christopher Morgan, To Renew the Human Face of the Earth, in *Theological Renewal* 10, Oct. 1978, pp. 14-23; Barbara Pursey, *Charismatic Power and Social Relevance: The Way of Renewed Discipleship*. Unpublished article of 20 pages, probably to be published by Presbyterian and Reformed Renewal Ministries International, Oklahoma City. Charismatic literature in German seems to be more consistently aware of societal issues than American charismatic publications. This is already evident from the title of the leading German charismatic periodical: *Erneuerung in Kirche und Gesellschaft*. Paderborn: Verlag Erneuerung.

precisely because the different parts of the body are to be dependent on one another.

The intentional communities with their mutual covenantal commitment present a strong challenge to current life-styles where the individual competes with everyone else to get to the top. Even where there is no established communal life it is not uncommon for charismatics to open up their nuclear family units to receive a single person into a household situation. In South Africa the Caring Community, led by Derek Crumpton, is a living testimony to this approach. The Catholic theologian, Francis Sullivan, states with respect to the strongly social (communal) character of charismatic groups: "Not a few prominent theologians are convinced that the future of Christianity in secular, unchristian, if not anti-christian society, is going to depend on the vitality of such spontaneous groups and communities of committed Christians as are forming through the charismatic renewal. What some are inclined to fear as the beginning of a sect may well turn out to be a pillar of strength for the Church of the future."²²

There is also a debit side with respect to individualism. It would be too good to be true if such a pervasive world-view did not influence the CRM as well. The most negative element of the CRM is probably the elitist holier-than-thou attitude which is found especially in those groups where "Spirit-baptism" is seen as the unique entrance into "first-class Christianity." It is this attitude which often leads to schisms and secessions. The CRM has had its share of problems with authority and authoritarianism. The Fort Lauderdale disciplinship controversy of the mid-seventies comes to mind. In my judgement, however, these problems are not more serious or more common amongst charismatics than can be found amongst non-charismatic Christians. All in all it can be said that the CRM has presented a biblically sound challenge to the current idol of Western individualism.

Modern society seems to have its very foundation in the concept of *materialism* — both in the sense of focusing on the selfish and greedy accumulation of personal wealth and the exhibiting of wasteful lifestyles as well as in the more primary sense of the denial of all spiritual realities and values. The CRM has opened up the whole realm of the so-called "supernatural" with fresh enthusiasm. Whereas the more "liberal" branches of Christianity have, since the Enlightenment, become increasingly more embarrassed by the so-called "primitive" and "miraculous" elements in the Bible, shifting them onto the periphery or explaining these references away by the use of ethical categories, and the more "conservative" churches have relegated the miracles to the dim and distant past by means of dispensational theories, the CRM has brought the manifestation of the "supernatural" onto centre-stage through the charisms of glossolalia, healing and prophecy in their midst. Even the reality of angels and demonic spirits is now taken

22. Francis Sullivan, What is a Pentecostal experience? A reply to a question raised by Simon Tugwell, in *Theological Renewal* 6, June/July 1977, p.25.

seriously. At the same time religious experience has come to be recognised as a legitimate part of the Christian life. After many decades in which spiritual experiences were considered to be signs of psychological imbalance or worse, here is an influential movement in Christianity professing direct encounters with God, supernatural guidance and “words of knowledge” from the Holy Spirit. This presents a serious challenge to the accepted ways of thinking in modernity and the scientific mind-set of Western civilisation. This challenge accounted for much of the unreasonable vehemence in the early opposition encountered by the CRM.

Materialism has also infiltrated the lives of charismatics. Although acknowledging the spiritual, many “renewed” Christians have not managed to avoid a materialistic life-style, especially considering the middle-class nature of most of the CRM in the English-speaking world. (This is, however, not true of charismatics in South America and India). The common purse and simple life-style of some covenant communities are restricted to a very small percentage of charismatics.

In the Independent “non-denominational” group of charismatics the so-called “Prosperity Gospel” has reared its head. In origin this teaching has more in common with metaphysical “New Thought” cults and Christian Science than with orthodox Christianity,²³ but it has influenced some schismatic groups of charismatics that have cut themselves off from the checks and balances of belonging to denominational Christianity. Although this teaching is meant to be a legitimate protest against the total spiritualising of the Gospel it often degenerates into materialism by planting the concept in people’s minds that we give to God in order to get his material blessings, that we should “confess” these desires into reality by the automatic, magical power of the spoken word, thereby also deflating the tension which exists in Christian life between the *already* and the *not yet* of eschatological consummation. This position is, none the less, not at all widely accepted in the CRM and is considered to be an aberration by charismatics of a sacramental and integrative theological stance.

* * *

In conclusion, then, the CRM should be recognised as presenting a formidable challenge to the world on this second level of world-view. Although not untainted by individualism and materialism the basic thrust of its witness has been inimical to these pervasive “principalities and powers of this world” (Eph. 5:12). It is in this sense that one can agree with Rifkin and Howard that the charismatics are providing a “liberating energy that is essential for any full-scale assault on the authority of the existing economic

23. This is pointed out in a Master’s dissertation: D.R. McConnell, *The Kenyon Connection: A theological and historical analysis of the cultic origins of the Faith Movement*. Oral Roberts University, 1982.

(and political) order” on a deep level, and that the CRM is thus, almost despite itself, more profoundly political than it realises.

In summary, then, the picture remains ambiguous. The CRM was found to be lacking in challenging the world on the level of structural and systematic evil, but does, in fact, present a significant and praiseworthy challenge on the level of contemporary idolatries such as individualism and materialism.